

## DARK AGES INVASION FORCE

# THE BATTLE OF HASTINGS

The victory of William of Normandy over the Anglo-Saxon King Harold II at the Battle of Hastings on 14 October 1066 was a turning point in English history. It was a close-fought battle in which the Anglo-Saxons narrowly failed to hold their ground against Norman cavalry and bowmen.

The death of Anglo-Saxon King Edward the Confessor in January 1066 triggered a succession struggle. Harold Godwinson, Earl of Wessex, was crowned king, but his right to the throne was contested by his brother Tostig and by William, Duke of Normandy. William immediately began assembling an invasion fleet at Dives-sur-Mer on the Normandy coast. By August he was ready to sail, but was prevented by the winds, which fortunately worked in his favour.

Having stood ready to face an invasion all summer, Harold's peasant army, the fyrd, had to be released to gather the harvest. Meanwhile Tostig had sought the aid of King Harald Hardrada of Norway, and in September Harald led his own invasion force across the North Sea. With his personal troops, the housecarls, and hastily raised levies, Harold marched north to defeat Harald at the Battle of Stamford Bridge. This left England's southern coast undefended.

## NORMAN INVASION

William sailed across the Channel, his soldiers and horses packed into 700 vessels, and landed unopposed at Pevensey in Sussex. He advanced along the coast to Hastings, while Harold hurried his army southward. On 13 October, William learned that the Anglo-Saxons were nearby, and the following morning he led his army out to meet them.

The strength of both forces is uncertain – estimates vary from a few thousand to tens of thousands on each side. Harold had taken up a strong defensive position on top of Senlac Ridge. His men were exhausted after the long journey from the north,

but resolute. They would fight on foot, clustered together in close formation, wielding two-handed axes or spears and depending on the protection of their shields and armour. William had a mixed force of infantry and cavalry at his disposal: they would have to attack uphill, but hoped to break up the tightknit Anglo-Saxon formation with the impact of their arrows and cavalry charges.

## THE LUCK OF THE DAY

The Norman bowmen opened the battle, attempting to soften up the enemy with their mix of simple bows and a few crossbows. Then the armoured infantry advanced uphill, the horsemen following behind. But the Anglo-Saxons stood firm as the Normans assailed their shield wall, bringing the attack to a halt. William was in the heart of the action. When some of his men began to fall back in disarray, the Norman leader reportedly pulled off his helmet to show his face and called out for them to renew their efforts. Eventually, in the turmoil of combat, some Anglo-Saxons were tempted to rush forward in pursuit where they saw Normans apparently retreating. They were cut down in a Norman counterattack. As the Anglo-Saxon forces weakened and lost formation, Norman horsemen were able to penetrate their ranks, wreaking havoc. The Anglo-Saxon housecarls pulled back in a tightening circle around their king. Norman arrows continued to rain down on them and, tradition has it, Harold was among their victims. He was certainly killed (whether by an arrow in the eye, or not, is disputed), and by the day's end the Normans held the field.

